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Some wins count double in terms of the message they send. And amid the blizzard of weekend Test matches it was Saturday night's result in Paris that will resonate the longest in both hemispheres. Not only the outcome, either, but the manner of it. To say South Africa exploded a few cosy theories would be the understatement of the rugby year.

So much for the idea, for example, that France would avenge the injustice of their [World Cup quarter-final defeat to the Springboks](#). That entering the final quarter with a narrow lead and an extra man would translate into inevitable glory. That even without their talisman Antoine Dupont they still had more than enough tranquiliser darts to keep the big beasts safely at bay.

Instead it was a case of counting their *poulets* prematurely. Having been 17-13 down, the 14-man Boks ended up [scoring 19 unanswered points](#), reinforcing their status as a side who increasingly save their best for the most challenging scenarios. If [beating New Zealand 43-10](#) in Wellington in September was a statement, here was conclusive proof the world's No 1 side are developing an even thicker skin.

If anything, Rassie Erasmus's champion Bok forwards are starting to make everyone else look laissez-faire by comparison. Scotland and England both had their moments over the weekend but possessed nothing like the same earthmovers that effectively reduced France to landfill in the last half-hour. Some promising young French forwards are coming through but, by the end, Saturday night was *hommes contre garçons*.

What was perhaps even more striking was the mental strength underpinning it all. Without Lood de Jager – shown a 38th-minute straight red for a shoulder to the head of Thomas Ramos – the Boks could easily have lost their composure. Instead they simply circled the wagons and set about dragging the deflated boys in blue to what the former French international hooker Benjamin Kayser called "the hurt locker."

Afterwards, having been borne aloft around the Stade de France on the gigantic shoulders of Eben Etzebeth and RG Snyman to celebrate his 100th cap, the Springbok captain, Siya Kolisi, once again stressed how many of his squad have been required to overcome off-field adversity and how he hoped his team would similarly continue to inspire others.

The ever-sage David Flatman also made an astute point on TNT Sport, suggesting Erasmus's record increasingly makes him the rugby coaching equivalent of Sir Alex Ferguson. If South Africa do go on to win a third successive World Cup there will be no doubt whatsoever. Even if they fall short, the smart way in which Erasmus has refreshed a potentially ageing squad has been an object lesson to all.

Look no further than his 23-year-old fly-half Sacha Feinberg-Mngomezulu who skipped over for the late try that properly blew open the French windows. Or Grant Williams, another half-back with lightning acceleration and an even sharper eye for a gap. Of course it helps to play behind a gargantuan pack, with André Esterhuizen riding shotgun, but the ongoing metamorphosis of the Boks from scowling heavyweights into a side who can also float like butterflies and sting like bees is hugely impressive.

Which is not to say France were totally outclassed, despite their limp finish. Damian Penaud's second try in the right corner was a good illustration. The power up front that tied in the Bok forwards, the glorious long pass from Ramos and Penaud's finishing dive into the advertising hoardings all displayed the hallmarks of a team with significant talent, even in the absence of Dupont.

But even that ultimately proved insufficient, which really is a sobering thought for everybody else. There is no way, for instance, that Scotland could have gone 17-0 down to South Africa and come galloping back in the way they did [against the All Blacks at Murrayfield](#). And for all England's last-quarter improvement, there remains a distance to travel before Steve Borthwick's squad can be confident of standing up to Erasmus's green-clad giants with everything on the line.

Beating an improving Fiji proved tricky enough on Saturday although the upcoming showdown against the All Blacks will be the fixture that properly defines their autumn. New Zealand are definitely still beatable, particularly without Jordie Barrett in their midfield, but when it comes to taking their chances they remain a cut above almost all the home unions.

Scotland were particularly guilty of failing to hammer home the final nails and question marks still hang over England's ideal backline blend. It is all very well finishing games strongly – and infinitely better than losing them late on – but their admirable nine-match unbeaten run this year has so far featured only one win over top-drawer opposition, a one-point home victory over France in February.

Hence the significance of this coming Saturday. Reading between the lines it would appear George Ford, Tom Roebuck (if fully fit) and either Freddie Steward or Elliot Daly will all return to the starting lineup, with Tommy Freeman possibly reverting to centre. Up front, likewise, Tom Curry, Sam Underhill and Maro Itoje should all be back from the start, most probably with Ben Earl at eight

But everything is relative, in sport as in life. Between now and the 2027 World Cup the rest now have to try to rein in a team who, in terms of rising to the biggest occasions, increasingly rank alongside the best ever to take a rugby field. And, judging by their 14-man masterclass in Paris, the Boks are far from done yet.

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